HIST 300: Indigenous Peoples of Canada to 1876

“Since Time Immemorial”

Week 1-2

Dr. Colin Osmond



Recap:

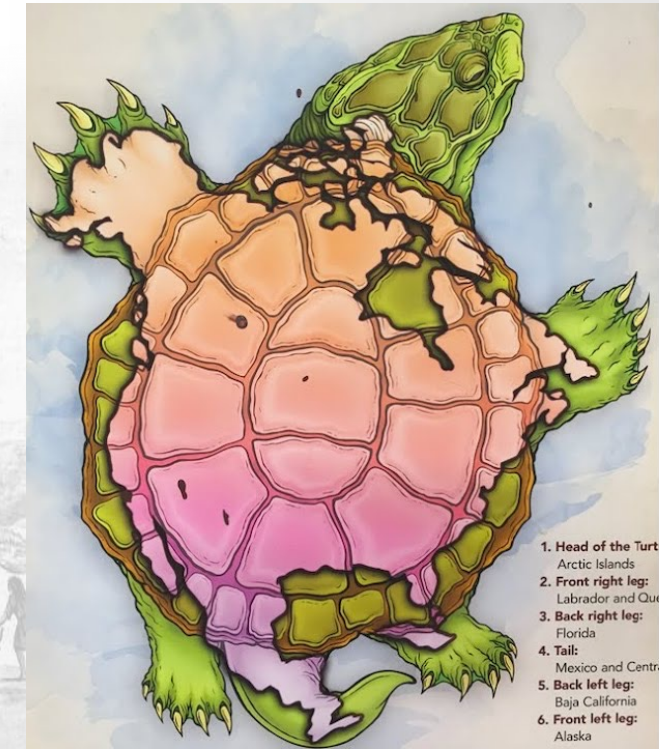
- What is History?
- The history of Canada is a collection of stories
- “Historical Consciousness”
  - Our individual and collective understanding of the past
  - Constantly evolving/changing
- Questions about course/syllabus?
- **REMINDER!** Reading Card #1 Due **Thursday Sept. 11 (1 week from Today)**!

Learning Outcomes/Keywords

- Understand the Creation Stories and theories on how Indigenous people populated Turtle Island
- Listen to and Learn from Indigenous Histories and Creation Stories
- The Problem with “X”
- Activity: Native-land.ca – Whose land is Canada on?
- Keywords: Creation, Time Immemorial, Turtle Island, Bering Land Bridge Theory, Pacific Coastal Migration Theory, European “Discovery”

In the beginning…

- What is a “creation story”?
  - Story? Legend? Myth? Theory?
- Critical Thinking
  - Who tell’s the story? What is their worldview? What is their motivation? Where did they get their info?
- Environmental history – geology
- Bering Land Bridge Theory
- Pacific Coastal Migration Theory
- European ‘Discovery’
- Indigenous Histories – Creation Stories – Oral Traditions



Creation Stories

- Oral transmission
- They describe the creation of the world and how people came to live on it
- They are not legends or myths – they are histories- they tell how the world came together, and how humans came to be a part of it.
- Some start before humans – with rocks, water, and dirt coming together.
- Others start with Animals
- They often take place over millennia

Creation Stories

- Syilx – The Four Food Chiefs
- “How Medicines Came to Man (Bear Legend)”
- Anishinaabe (Ontario/Quebec) – “The Otter”


Food Chiefs!

“The Otter” – Joan Tenasco (Anishinabe)

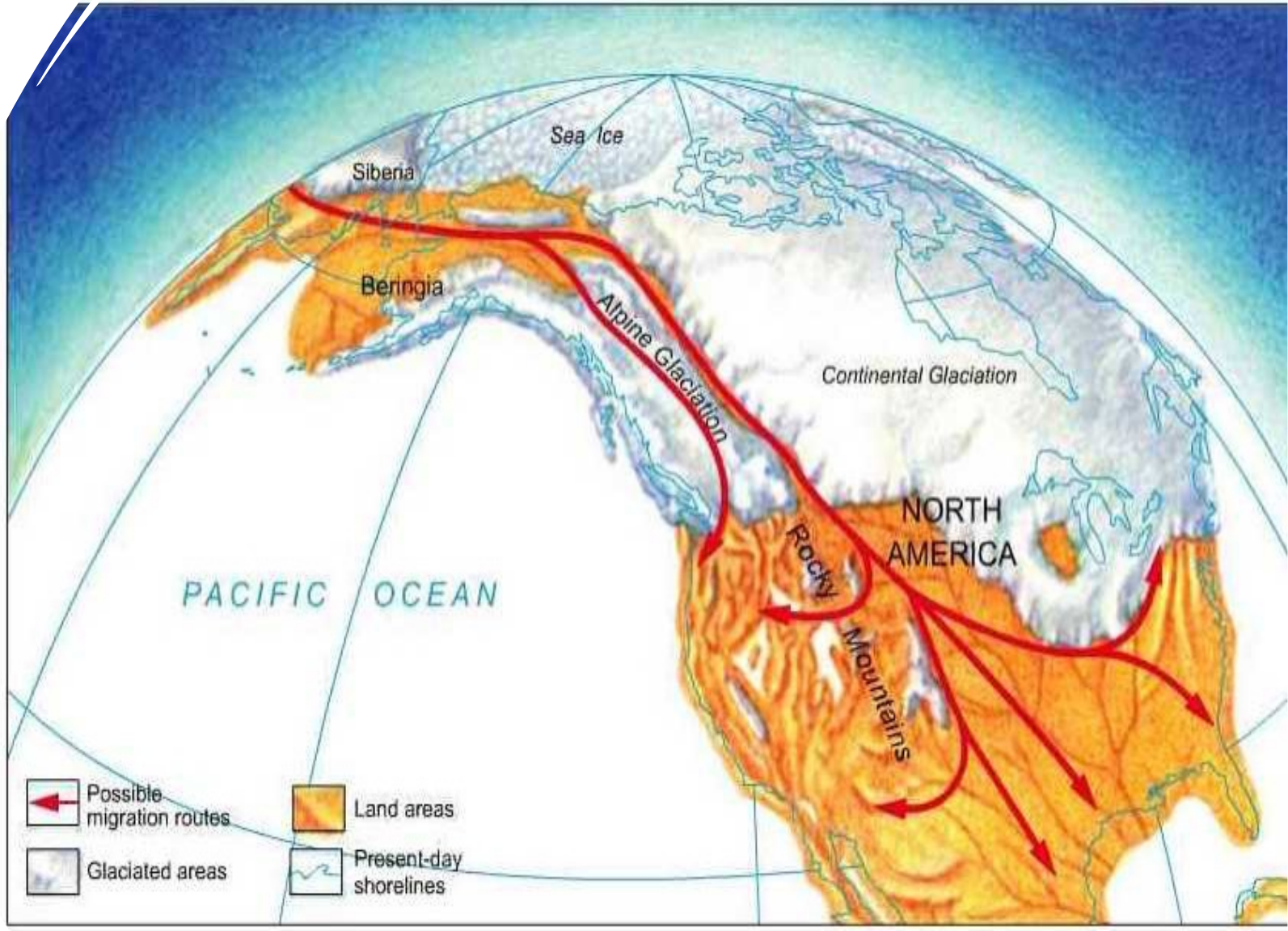
It is said when the Great Spirit created the earth, he called a meeting with all the spirits. The Great Spirit discussed his intention to put human beings on the earth and they would play an important role in his creation. He asked the spirits how they wanted to help the people. Each spirit came forward and counselled with the Great Spirit on the ways they could and would help the people. Among these was the guardian spirit of the Otter. He went before the Great Spirit and said, “Because of my character and nature, I will help the people to work together in your creation. When they want to live in harmony with themselves and your creation, I will educate and instruct the people in teachings to protect their family and group. When they need me I will show the people the direction to unity. I will serve this purpose.” The Great Spirit approved of the Otter`s request and chose the Otter to be the guardian of unity for the Anishinàbeg.

These are the words that were given by a knowledge keeper who has since passed on.
Written by: Rene Tenasco Ashkàbewis. Council member, 1993, Kitigàn Zìbì Anishinàbeg.



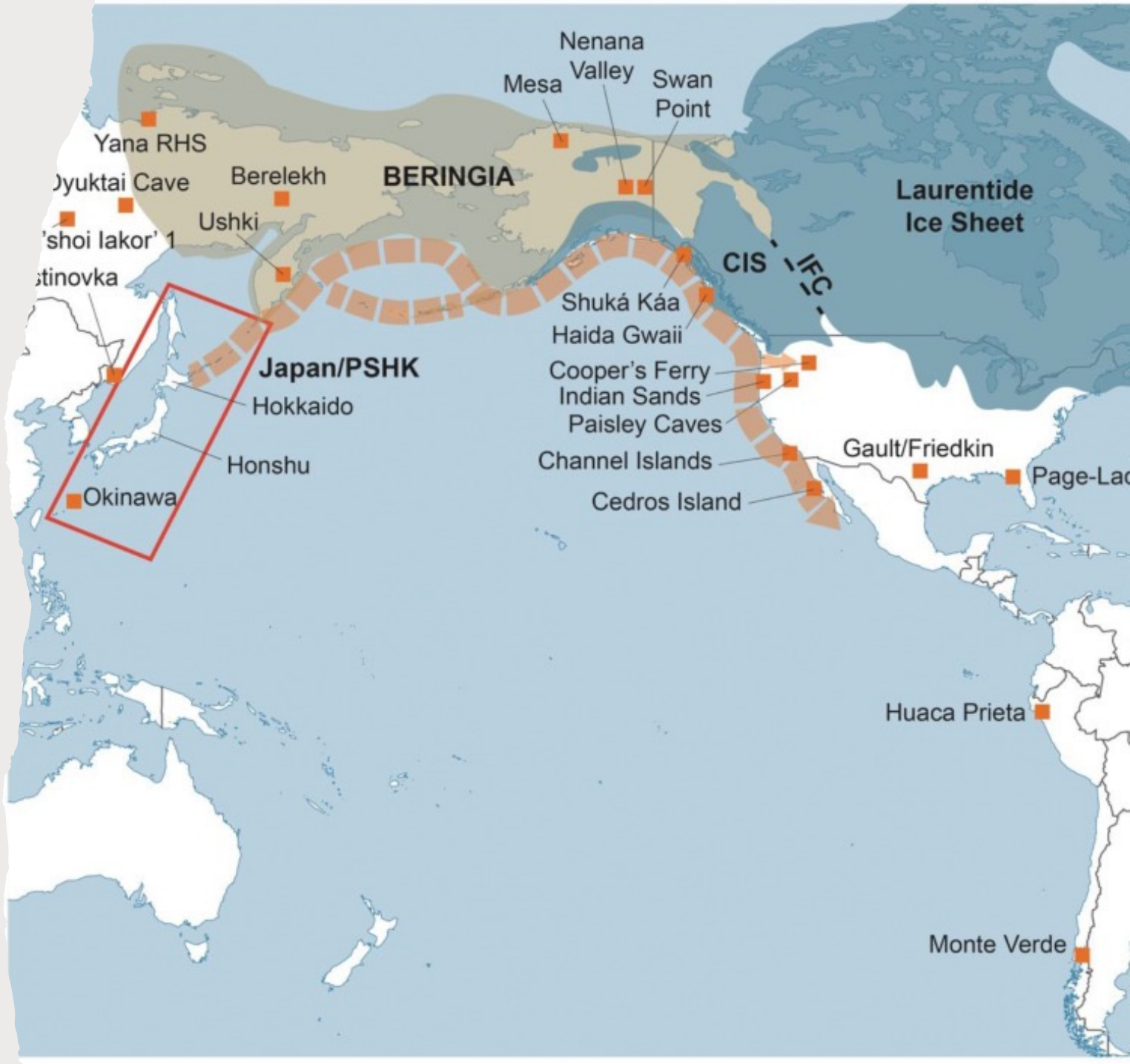
Bering Land Bridge Theory

- Ice free corridor from Siberia to Great Plains
- Human migration 16,500-10,000 years ago



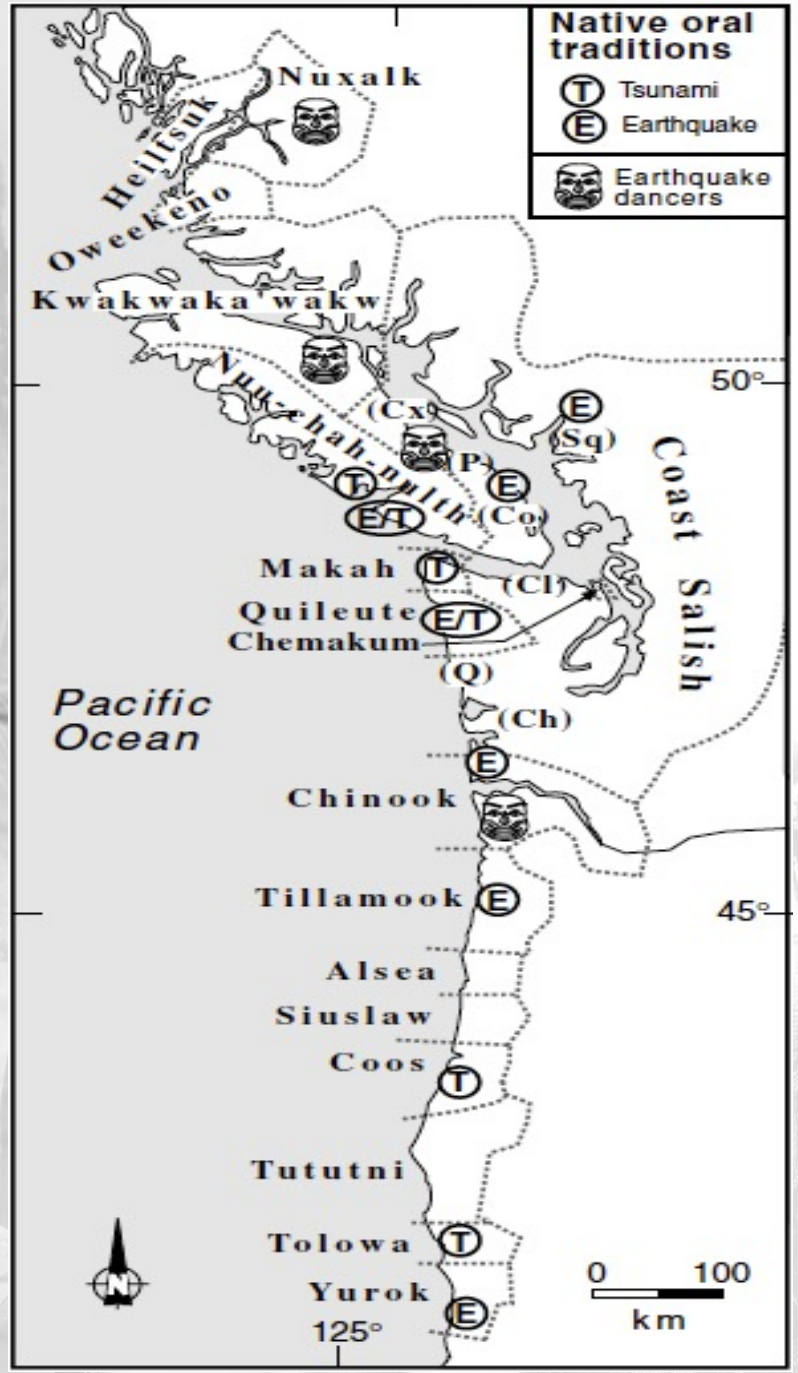
Pacific Migration Theory

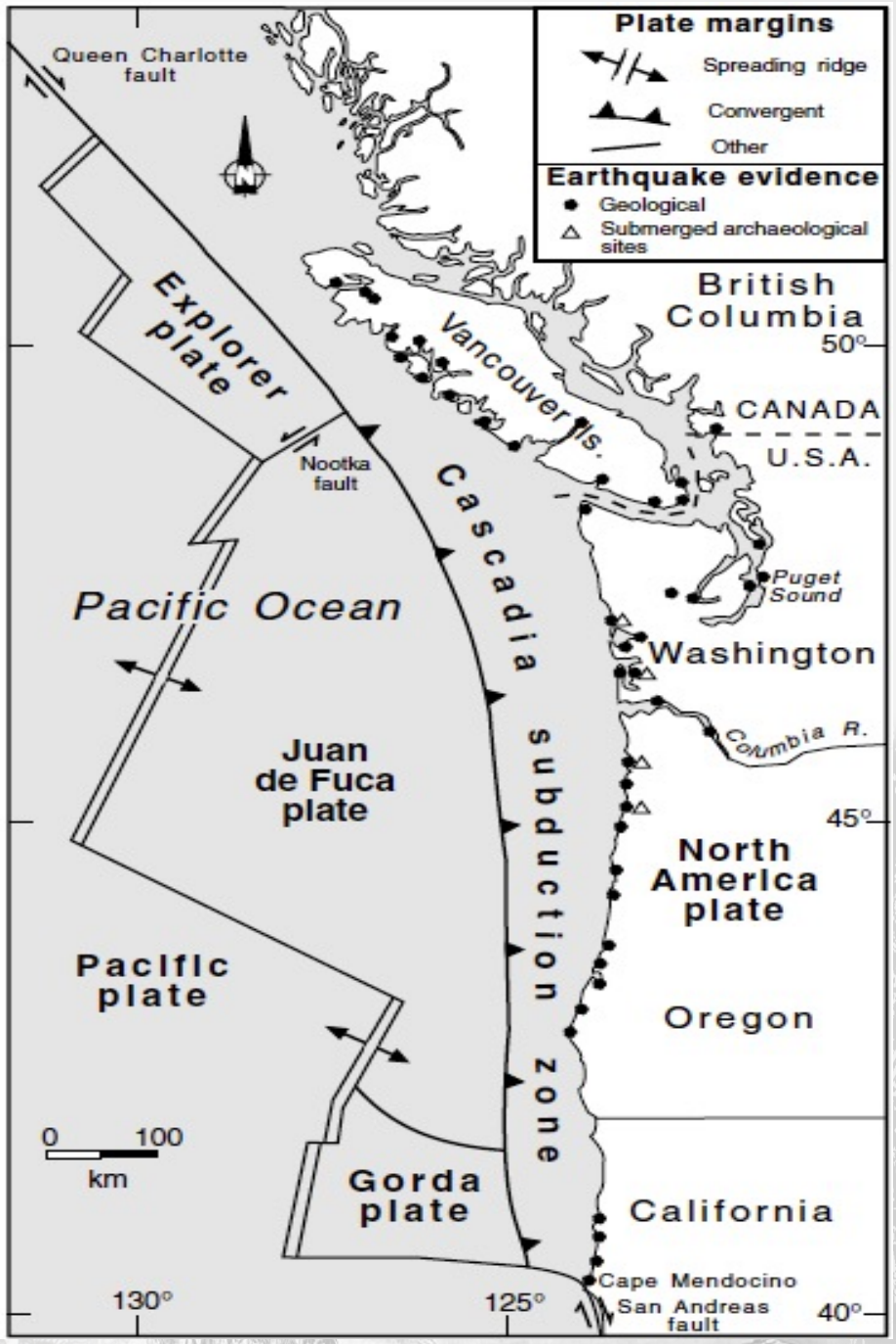
- Sea levels lower (150 ft.) than today
- Travelled along Pacific Coast
- May have happened before, during, and after Bering Theory



The Problem with X

- New findings (new sites, better technology, new methods, etc.) challenge previous theories
- Most believe there were several migrations over time
  - Some Coastal, some over land
- “X” will always be a theory
- What if “X” doesn’t exist?


Native oral traditions
Tsunami
Earthquake
Earthquake dancers
Nuxalk
Hellitsuk
Oweekeno
Kwakwaka'wakw
Nuu-chah-nulth
Coast Salish
Makah
Quileute
Chemakum
Pacific Ocean
Chinook
Tillamook
Alsea
Siuslaw
Coos
Tututni
Tolowa
Yurok
50°
45°
125°
0 100
km


Plate margins
Spreading ridge
Convergent
Other
Earthquake evidence
Geological
Submerged archaeological sites
Queen Charlotte fault
Explorer plate
Nootka fault
Juan de Fuca plate
Pacific plate
Gorda plate
Cascadia subduction zone
Pacific Ocean
Vancouver Is.
British Columbia
CANADA
U.S.A.
Puget Sound
Washington
Columbia R.
North America plate
Oregon
California
Cape Mendocino
San Andreas fault
0 100
km
50°
45°
40°
130°
125°

Activity

- Group with the people around (4-5 in a group)
- Discuss what you found on Native-land.ca (10 mins)
- Come back to a larger group discussion – one (or more!) person will speak on what your group discussed



Conclusion

- Several Theories on how Indigenous people populated North America
  - Bering Land Bridge
  - Pacific Coastal Migration
    - Most Scholars accept that both happened – just not sure when
- No Migration – here Since time immemorial
- Chasing a constantly earlier X
- Theories – stories backed with evidence
  - Not all evidence is created equal – Solutrean Theory

Next Class:

Sept 12 White Sails on the Horizon: Contacts in the Atlantic World

- Read: William C. Wicken, 160-175.
- Belshaw: Pgs. 39-45.
- Review Primary Sources on Canvas for in-class discussion (no reading, just images)